

NEVERWINTER NIGHTS

Role-playing was never this fun

With a development cycle that's been longer than four years, *Neverwinter Nights* (NWN) was planned as a major milestone in the role-playing genre of computer games. The final product comes very close to delivering its promise.



MEET NEW PEOPLE...THEN CRUSH THEM: The game pits you against beasts of all kinds and make

Based on the third edition of *Dungeons and Dragons* rule-set, NWN comes packaged in three CDs, complete with a cloth map for reference and a hefty 218 page manual. With over 22 pre-made characters running the gamut from Halfling monks, to Elven wizards and swashbuckling rogues, the game packs enough personalities to suit your fancy

and to get you up and running with just a few clicks. NWN uses the brand-spanking-new Aurora engine to immerse you into an interactive 3D world. The idiosyncrasies of camera-control and the RPG concepts of inventory management and leveling up are succinctly explained via a useful tutorial, masquerading as the prologue to an epic story.

The animations are top-notch—your character will swing, block, parry and duck enemy attacks, adding an amazing layer of realism and immersion. Lighting effects bring day and night cycles and real shadows. All these ingredients are brought together in locations ranging from foggy hilltops, to water-filled caverns that are swamped with monsters big and small, with attitudes to match.

The game tells a winding story that takes you on a voyage across cities and towns, both in and out of this world. You can pair up with one computer-controlled character that the game terms as a henchman. Moreover, you can summon and command creatures and if you created

character allows for it, choose a familiar (a character) to be part of your adventuring party. Fans of previous BioWare games such as *Baldur's Gate I and II* might be disappointed with the limited number of party members, or by the reduced level of interaction amongst them. Other pitfalls include some minor hiccups with path finding and other AI routines, and some not-so-minor ones that involve your game crashing to the desktop. Patches are coming in fast and hopefully these problems will soon be resolved.

The visuals are very well supported by excellent sound effects that include cries of pain and taunts to incite your enemies. The music rendered by industry veteran Jeremy Soule provides an excellent bridge between hectic battles and the tending to wounds that follow. Add to this the ability to play co-operatively with friends over a LAN, or on the Net and the fact that you can create your own adventures, it becomes obvious that the game offers an excellent package to play with.

Although not without its flaws, it does not take too long to appreciate NWN for what it is—an excellent role-playing experience.

Genre: Role Playing ■ **Developer:** BioWare ■ **Distributor:** Milestone Interactive ■ **Phone:** 022-8381614
Web site: www.bioware.com ■ **Price:** NA ■ ★★★★★

ALFRED HITCHCOCK: THE FINAL CUT

Cut it out!

Alfred Hitchcock's *Psycho* may have sent a chill down your spine but *The Final Cut* leaves a lot to be desired. You enter the plot as Joseph Shamley, a private detective hired by a young and beautiful mute, Alicia, niece of the pharmaceutical tycoon Robert Marvin Jordan. You have to uncover the mysterious overnight disappearance of your client's uncle and



HELLO DUMMY: Joseph gets his first shooting lesson while filming a scene

first chapter of the game, there is a vast

his entire film crew while shooting a Hitchcock film.

Aside from a seemingly unrealistic plot, the game also suffers from irritating shifts in camera angles as you move around. Surprisingly, as you get into the

environment to explore, but moving your character around is a pain, as you can only do so using the arrow keys.

The environments are well designed and look quite appealing, although the same cannot be said for the character models, and Joseph's conversations with other characters are mostly monosyllabic and rigid. The game does have its moments though, such as the part where you're exploring the family burial ground which is accompanied by some eerie music. All in all, what you would really need to enjoy this game, is a whole lot of patience.

Genre: Adventure ■ **Developer:** Arxel Tribe ■ **Distributor:** Alladin Multimedia ■ **Phone:** 022-7895085/7903959
Web site: www.arxel.com ■ **Price:** Rs 999 ■ ★☆☆☆☆